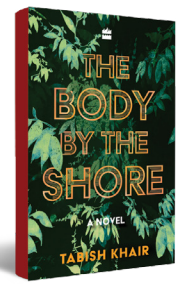
The Good, the Bad and the Ugly

Heroism and villainy overlap as all characters come together in **Tabish Khair**'s tale of redemption and damnation

Jens Erik, an ex-policeman, is an unlikely hero. To his daughter, he is embarrassingly racist. To his former colleagues he is a Luddite. His mind keeps returning to the body of a Black man recovered from the sea some years previously. Harris Malouf is an unlikely villain, a killer now leading a quiet life tending to his garden and an assortment of swans.

The *Body By the Shore* is a tale of redemption and damnation; but if the good guys win and the bad guys lose, who is which? And to what degree? Knowledge in the hands of the 'wrong' people can be destructive, but who decides that? Larger questions come accompanied by smaller ones—do we have a responsibility to keep ourselves informed?

When the characters all come together at an oil rig in the North Sea, now an unlikely resort and place of dark secrets, heroism and villainy overlap. Scientists as killers, killers as saviours, bad guys arriving in time to save another set of bad guys, human guinea pigs robbed of their humanity—all remind us that the masks we wear may be temporary; the faces we sport change with need.



THE BODY BY THE SHORE
By Tabish Khair
HARPERCOLLINS PUBLISHERS INDIA
₹399, 322 pages

In a book like this, that is science fiction, murder mystery, spy thriller, cop story, political drama and love story set in the near future, the chances of any one of the genres upsetting the overall balance are great. Especially since the stories are narrated in different voices and remain separate for long. What keeps the balance intact is the tension. Tabish Khair piques the reader's curiosity, and that's the magic formula. He performs a literary juggling act with great skill and much enjoyment.

The mixture works because Khair writes with intelligence and assumes the reader's intelligence too. Even the irritants—some over-explained passages, for example—do not cause annoyance because of this. With so many varied characters, the chances of some being mere stick figures are great too. The author seems aware of this and gives us convincing backstories that drive everything towards that oil rig with patent inevitability. The past, present and future come together in a neat package; where scientists push the boundaries of the possible, there are always ruthless organisations waiting to take advantage.

Khair, a poet of repute and a writer of gentle, flowing sentences, gives us a scary post-pandemic world. We can change, but only if we make the effort, as Jens Erik does. We must cling to our discomforts for that. ■

Suresh Menon

THE BEST OF 2022

Lost In Translations

By Daisy Rockwell



Daisy Rockwell *is a painter and translator of Urdu and Hindi literature, notably Geetanjali Shree's 2022 Booker-winning* ***Tomb of Sand***

As a translator, I'm very picky when it comes to reading translations. The key to success is to pay attention to who your translator is. Once you find the one you love, hunt down more titles by the same translator, because you are bound to find more great books in the process. My list of five great reads from 2022 are all translations, all brought to English by highly skilled fellow-translators.

People from Bloomington (Penguin Random House), by Budi Darma, was translated from Indonesian by Tiffany Tsao. This is a classic Indonesian collection and the English version is flawless. Darma writes about his time in Bloomington, Indiana, USA, from a fascinating and quirky perspective invoking the bland Midwestern landscape to a tee. *Rouge Street* (Metropolitan Books) by Shuang Xuetao was translated from Chinese by Jeremy Tiang. This translation is, in the words of the K-pop band BTS, smooth like butter. The three novellas are set in Shenyang, China, known as the Rust Belt of China. Bleak, macabre and even fantastical, this book is a page-turner.

Two novels on my list, *Violets* (Feminist Press), by Kyung-Shook Shin, translated from Korean by Anton Hur, and *All the Lovers in the Night* (Kodansha) by Mieko Kawakami, translated from Japanese by Sam Bett and David Boyd, belong to a genre I didn't previously realise existed: contemporary tales of alienated urban Asian women. Both novels push the theme of female urban isolation to the brink of absolute despair. The writing is beautiful and spare, and incidentally, all three talented translators were shortlisted for the International Booker Prize in 2022.

Finally, I am still reading and loving *Beloved Rongomala* (Eka, Westland), by Shaheen Akhtar, translated from Bangla by Shabnam Nadiya. The novel is set in 18th-century Bengal and revolves around the audacious mistress of a minor king, Rongomala, who demands that a lake be created in her honour. Nadiya's delicious translation brings the poetry of the novel to life in English. ■



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4. ALL THE LOVERS IN THE NIGHT, by Mieko Kawakami, translated from Japanese by Sam Bett and David Boyd
5. BELOVED RONGOMALA, by Shaheen Akhtar, translated from Bangla by Shabnam Nadiya